

Android on Amazon

Amazon has launched its own platform for Android apps making it easier for users to search and download them

Chrome 11

Google adds HTML 5 speech input capability to Chrome 11 Beta

Android Phone test

And the winner is

Given the comparable feature set and performance of these three phones, a winner became a matter of better value, which simply means the most affordable phone to win. The Micromax A60 wins our Best Buy award and for a price of ₹7,999 is the cheap Android phone to get.

Phones between ₹10,001 and ₹17,500 A tricky bunch

Most people shopping for an Android phone will be looking to spend in this price bracket. For the price, you do not get a top-notch Android device. Therefore the perception of Android being a high-end platform hasn't been proven wrong, especially given you can buy a reasonably high-end Symbian device like the Nokia E72 for around ₹15,000. However, you do get a lot of options, in fact, sorting through them is not an easy task. At this point, you need to get your priorities right – do you want a great camera and a good multimedia device, or do you want a well-rounded device. It is also interesting to note that the phones within this price range also have smaller displays – we were surprised after checking prices to find no 3.7-inch display-bearing phone available for less than ₹17,500.

Features, build and usability

There's a lot more variety in this category. From the Samsung Galaxy Fit and the LG Optimus One P500 that are touchscreen-only Android devices to the Sony Ericsson Xperia X10 Mini Pro that integrates a small, yet surprisingly usable QWERTY keypad, to the Sony Ericsson Xperia X8

that comes with a number of attractive back covers, and is obviously aimed at the swanky college-goer, to the unusual Motorola Flipout, that features a very unique form factor and conceals a QWERTY keypad in a rather small footprint.

The Sony Ericsson X10 Mini and X10 Mini Pro are tiny phones – the Pro adds a slide-out keypad. The Xperia X8 is slightly larger, and all these phones feature plastic bodies, that nevertheless feel solid on account of their compactness. The HTC Wildfire looks very similar to a few other larger HTC phones, except that it has a 3.2-inch display. To our dismay, none of the phones in this group had a high-resolution display – the best we got was 320 x 480 pixels.

The Samsung Galaxy Fit stood out as being a bit plain looking, with an exaggerated rounding at the edges. While the small Sony Ericsson X10 Mini Pro manages with a well spaced out keypad that has small keys, the larger Samsung Galaxy 551 has a more spaced out keypad, but with less spacing between the keys. This makes it a great keypad to quickly type of SMS' and mails; Samsung has learned from the Samsung Corby Pro.

Quite a few of the devices in this group missed flash units – surprisingly so, for this is a feature one expects on most cellphones with half decent cameras.

Performance

The Galaxy Fit had some weird issues in zone three, where call clarity dipped. There was static on the line, and the call disconnected thrice. We didn't notice any such issues in the other two zones, and clarity on loudspeaker and earpiece

HOW WE TESTED

For the purposes of testing we categorised the phones into four groups on the basis of price – up to ₹10,000, ₹10,001 to ₹17,500, ₹17,501 to ₹23,000 and above ₹23,000. We used street prices for this division, and not MRPs. We used our own class 10 SanDisk microSD 16 GB card for recording images, videos and even storing music files. Bluetooth transfers were done to this memory card, and we didn't use any of the phones' internal memory. Before testing, the phone's battery was charged fully. After this, we upgraded each of the phones to the latest firmware available. In case of the Samsung Galaxy S, we couldn't perform the upgrade, since it seemed the phone came to us with a custom firmware, therefore we stuck with Android 2.1. After a firmware upgrade, the memory card was formatted, and a factory reset was done to restore everything to its native form. We used an Airtel SIM throughout, and the Bluetooth tests were carried out using an Apple MacBook Pro unibody, that supports Bluetooth 2.1.

This time round, we've divided our table into three scoring components – features, build and ergonomics and performance. Here build and ergonomics includes the look, feel and construction of a product as well as its ergonomics, usability and intuitiveness.

The heading "features" doesn't include any testable parameters, but contains device characteristics that we rate – for example address book capacity, connectivity options, certain camera specs, hot swap of the memory card, USB charging among others. Under build we give a score that includes the look, fit and finish, surface materials and quality of moving parts. We look at the shortcut buttons, their intuitiveness, the keypad and its usability to quickly type. When looking at keys and controls, we also check their feedback when used, and the level of ergonomics. If the phone has a touchscreen we rate its usability, sensitivity and accuracy, as well as the usability of the onscreen keypad. We also look at the menu system – how well and intelligently laid out is it, how well are options presented, and to what extent can it be tailored to suit an individual i.e. level of customisation.

Under performance, we divide our call clarity test into three zones, on the basis of signal strength. Zone one and two represent normal usage in city, with excellent to mediocre signal reception. Zone three represents poor reception where the phone shows below 25 per cent of signal strength. We rate calls on the basis of clarity both sides of the line, presence of distortion and so on. Loudspeaker, earpiece and handsfree clarity and volume levels on call are also tested. We also test music quality using two MP3 files encoded at 320 kbps at constant bitrates.

The camera is tested for colour reproduction and sharpness of focus, as well as the detail level it is capable of. All these scores are given on a scale of 10. Finally we grade the display itself – resolution and crispness, colour, and of course sunlight visibility.

was fairly good. We were in for another surprise – the Sony Ericsson Xperia X8 gave us a whopping Bluetooth transfer score of 239 KBps and it was nearly twice as fast as some of the high-end phones.

The Sony Ericsson Xperia X10 Mini has a really nice loud-

speaker for music. Not only is it loud, the quality is also good. This phone is suitable for using as an MP3 player. The HTC Wildfire had a very mediocre handsfree unit – we found volume levels sorely lacking. Even earpiece clarity on the HTC Wildfire is mediocre.